Using different languages inclusively in learning activities

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D19-S1

Explain how students may draw on their languages during a task and how everyone will access the shared reasoning. Plan language use around learning goals, participation and course requirements. Students should be able to choose whether to use or disclose their languages.

How to plan language use for a task

- Check the task purpose and any course or assessment language requirements. Make the required output language explicit.
- Identify stages where students may use languages they find helpful, such as private notes, reading preparation or initial idea development.
- Plan how ideas will be shared with everyone. Require a summary in the group's shared language, supported by diagrams or key terms where useful.
- Explain the arrangement before students begin. Do not assume students share a language because of their background.
- Monitor participation. If someone cannot follow the discussion, pause and ask the group to restate the reasoning in the agreed shared language.
- Check the final subject understanding and required output. Invite students to say whether the arrangement helped them contribute.

Example wording

"You may make private notes using any languages that help you think. For this group task, explain your reasoning in English so everyone can discuss it. Include the key subject terms and a diagram if useful. The group's final recommendation must be in English."

Keep participation voluntary

Students may prefer to work entirely in English. Do not assign a student to translate for a group or represent a language community. If translation is volunteered, check that the meaning is shared and avoid relying on one person throughout.

Example - environmental science

Prepare individually: Students examine a water quality graph and note possible causes of the changes. They may use any languages for private notes.

Share with the group: Each student gives a short English explanation using the graph and the terms concentration, source and trend. Allow preparation time.

Build a shared explanation: The group compares causes and asks clarification questions. If a brief exchange uses another language, the relevant reasoning is restated in English before the group decides.

Produce the required output: The group writes an English recommendation supported by two pieces of evidence. Follow the course requirements for any assessed version.

Task planning prompts

- What subject learning is this task intended to develop?
- Which preparation stages allow students to choose their language?
- What language is required for shared discussion and final output?
- How will students who do not share a language access every important idea?
- What will I do if a group member is excluded?

Check local requirements

For assessment, use the published language and tool rules. Permission to use preferred languages in preparation does not automatically authorise translation tools or AI assistance. Clarify the applicable requirements before the task.

Supporting Sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Fostering Linguistically Inclusive and Asset Based Classroom*